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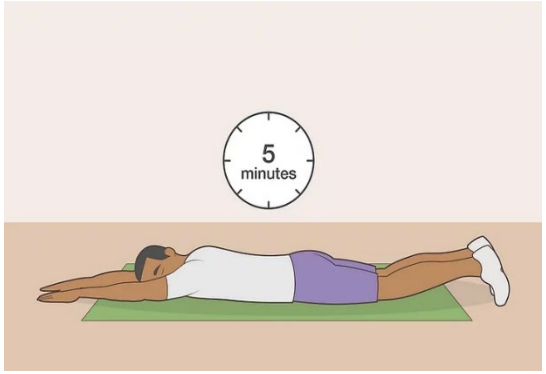
Lumbar Spine McKenzie Exercises
Home Exercise Program

1. Lying Face Down

Lie flat on your stomach for 5 minutes at a time. Find a comfortable place to lie down on a bed or on the floor. Keep your arms out in front of you and turn your head to the side. While you're lying down, take deep breaths so you can relax. Stay in a prone position for about 5 minutes at a time, and repeat the exercise about twice a day.

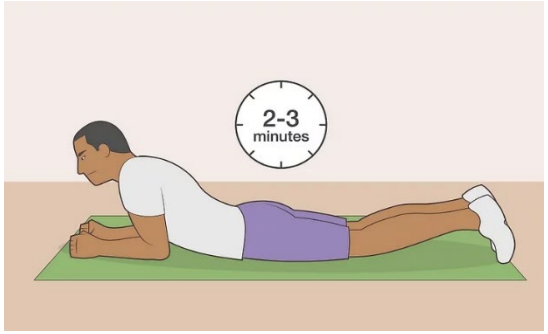
- If you still feel pain just from lying on your stomach, try putting a pillow under your stomach. After you feel comfortable on the pillow, try doing the exercise without one.
- Try squeezing your glutes together as tight as you can while you're in this position to help your lumbar support.



2. Lying Face Down in Extension

Prop yourself up on your elbows while you lie on your stomach. Start in a prone position with your arms tucked underneath your chest. Press your forearms into the floor to lift your upper body up as far as you can without feeling pain. Keep your lower body relaxed so your hips stay against the ground and your spine stays curved. Get in this position around 8 times each day for 2–3 minutes at a time.

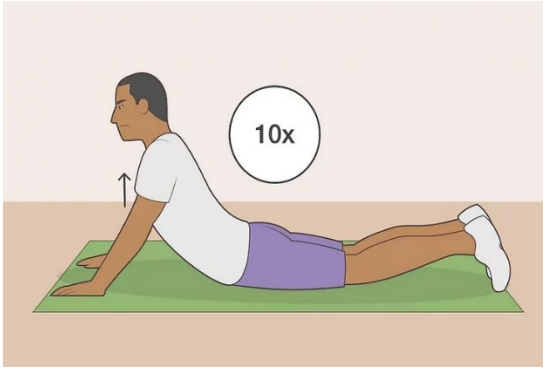
- Don't try this exercise if you feel pain from just lying on your stomach since this might hurt even more.



3. Extension Lying Down (Press Ups)

Lie down on your stomach so your hands are right underneath your shoulders. Straighten your arms so you lift your upper body off of the floor as far as you're able. Make sure you keep your lower body relaxed so your hips and legs stay down against the floor. Hold your position for 10 seconds before lowering yourself back down. Do 1 or 2 sets every day that are 10 repetitions each.

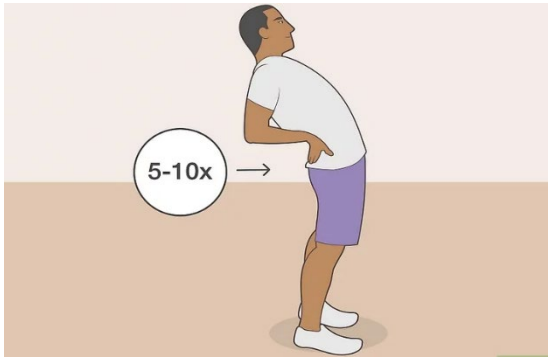
- To make this exercise easier for you, take a deep breath when you're at the bottom position. Hold your breath as you lift your body and exhale at the top.
- If you feel too much pain when your arms are directly below your shoulders, try moving your hands further out in front of you so your back doesn't curve as much.



4. Extension in Standing (Back Bends)

Put your hands on your lower back and lean backward while standing. Stand with your feet shoulder-width apart and press your palms against your lower back. Look straight ahead and slowly bend backward at the hips as far as you can without feeling any pain or falling over. Then return to your starting position. Aim to do about 5–10 reps at a time when you're feeling pain.

- Keep your upper back straight throughout the exercise since this only targets your lower back.
- This exercise doesn't stretch your back as well as prone press-ups, but it is easier to do if you need to stretch in an office or public place.



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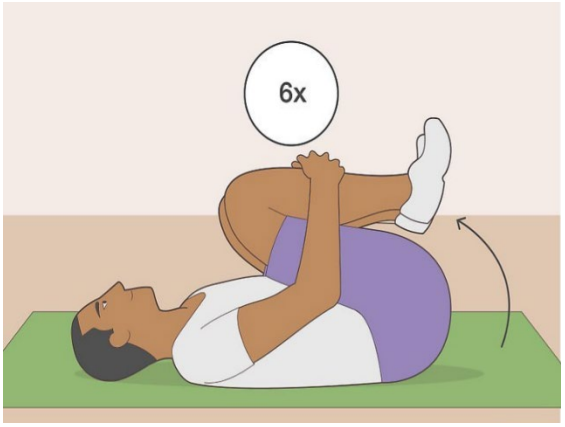
5. Flexion in Lying

Lie on your back and drive your knees toward your chest. Lie on your back so your knees are bent and your feet are flat on the floor. Lift your legs off of the ground and slowly drive your knees up toward your chest. Wrap your arms around your knees and pull them even closer to your body for an even deeper stretch. Hold your position for 2 counts before relaxing again. Do about 4 sets that are each around 6 repetitions.

- If you feel a lot of pressure on your spine, try putting a pillow under your head for some relief.
- Don't lift your hips or back off of the floor while you're doing this exercise.This stretch helps you feel less pain when you're bending forward.



6. Sitting Correctly

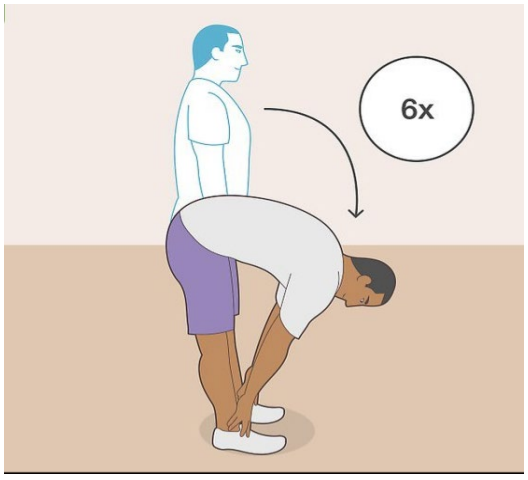
Bend forward in a chair and slide your hands underneath it. Sit right on the edge of a chair with your knees bent and feet firmly planted on the floor. Start with your back straight and bend forward at the hips as far as you can. Reach out in front of you with your hands and touch the floor. Arch your back and slide your hands underneath the chair as far as you can. Hold your position for 2 seconds before sitting up straight again. Do this stretch 4 times a day for 6 repetitions each time.

- Breathe in as you're leaning forward and exhale right before you sit up to help your body relax.

7. Reaching your toes correctly

Lean forward and touch your feet while you're standing. Stand with your feet shoulder-width apart and your hands on your thighs. Whenever you're ready, bend your upper body forward and slide your hands down your legs. Keep your knees straight and reach down as far as you comfortably can. As soon as you get to the lowest position, slowly straighten your back to the starting position. Do 2 sets every day with 6 repetitions each.

- Don't worry if you can't reach your feet right away. It can takes little bit of time to relieve your pain and increase your flexibility.
- Avoid bending your knees, or else you won't work your lower back as well.



8. Lifting Correctly

Keep your back straight as you lift the load with your legs. Hug the object tightly against your chest as you straighten your legs. Support as much of the weight as you can just using your legs. Don't arch or bend your back as you lift the object since it may cause pain. Keep lifting the object until you're in a standing position.

- If you start lifting the object but can't get back into standing position, set it down and ask for help. Don't carry the object if you're straining to lift it.